



"It seemed impossible until it was done. It almost felt like we had held our breath while working away. It's like walking on eggshells. Every step we take matters"

— DR HAMID JAFARI, *Former project manager, National Polio Surveillance Project, WHO India*



FROM THE ARCHIVES
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Health **Putting the Lid Back**

In 2001, with just 268 cases of polio, Indian health officials were convinced the country would be polio-free by 2002, the initial WHO international deadline. In 2002, India saw an unexpected polio epidemic, with 1,600 cases, 83 per cent of all global cases.

Of these, 65 per cent were from Uttar Pradesh. More worrying was the spread of the epidemic to previously polio-free areas of Gujarat, Rajasthan and West Bengal. The UP strain was detected in even in Lebanon. It shook the government out of complacency. (It saw the) launching of the largest ever mass immunisation campaign against polio in 2003, targeting 165 million children.

–Supriya Bezbaruah

LESSONS FROM A WAR

- **Elimination of polio in the country proved that eliminating a disease in such a large country is possible**
- **India's success became a template for other countries where polio was endemic. Nigeria has now become polio-free; the battle continues in Afghanistan and Pakistan**
- **India's experience in polio vaccination involving local health workers came in useful during the country's mass vaccination programme for Covid-19, where India delivered the highest number of doses worldwide**
- **The project also demonstrated how community influencers and celebrities like Amitabh Bachchan, Shah Rukh Khan and Sachin Tendulkar could be roped in for elimination of diseases such as TB, cancer and Covid-19**

DID YOU KNOW?

Polio is the second infectious disease to be eradicated in India after smallpox was declared eradicated in 1977

1
BILLION

OPV doses given to 172 million children each year in the 4 years leading up to the last case in 2011

introduced the Inactivated Polio Vaccine (IPV) in its immunisation programme to consolidate the gains of polio eradication. There is certainly no room for complacency. Just this August, a case of vaccine-derived polio was reported in a child in Meghalaya.

Eternal vigilance is something the world can ill afford to ignore if it wants to eliminate polio, not just eradicate it. But there have been undeniable takeaways from India's journey toward ending the scourge. For one, it cemented public confidence in public healthcare, in health workers and in vaccines. The programme also served as a good example of how non-state actors can fund, plan and implement public health programmes alongside the government. ■